

Hail to the Chief: The Impact of New Presidents on College Employment

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Abstract

This paper examines how changes in college presidents affect institutional employment. Using annual IPEDS data from 2013–2023 and an event study design that exploits the timing of leadership transitions at 720 primarily baccalaureate institutions, we track staffing adjustments across twelve occupational categories. We find that presidential transitions are followed by gradual but persistent declines in total employment, driven by reductions in instructional staff, student and academic affairs personnel, office and administrative support staff, and facilities and maintenance workers. These effects typically emerge two to three years after the transition and grow over time, consistent with restructuring through attrition, hiring freezes, and operational consolidation rather than immediate layoffs. In contrast, eight occupational categories—including IT staff, graduate assistants, management, healthcare personnel, and service workers—show no systematic response to new leadership. The results suggest that presidents do matter for how institutions allocate labor, but their influence is uneven, targeted, and realized slowly through routine budget cycles rather than dramatic short-term shifts.

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1 Introduction

In 2023, the New College of Florida (NCF)—a small public liberal arts college long known for its progressive identity and emphasis on academic freedom—became the focus of national attention when its board of trustees selected former state education commissioner Richard Corcoran as interim president and later confirmed him as the institution’s permanent leader ([Associated Press, 2023](#); [Wilson, 2024](#)). The appointment prompted widespread debate among students, faculty, alumni, and policymakers over the future direction of the institution.

College presidents are no longer seen merely as campus administrators; they are symbolic and strategic actors whose decisions can affect faculty composition, student recruitment, and institutional reputation. The attention surrounding Corcoran’s and other presidential appointments begs an important question: *Do presidents matter?* Seminal work by [Cohen and March \(1974\)](#) contends that the presidency is largely “an illusion,” constrained by bureaucracy, shared governance, and external forces. On the one hand, the Association of Governing Boards of Universities and Colleges asserts that “strong, assertive, and enlightened presidents” drive colleges to “a new and higher level of contribution.”

While prior studies have examined the effects of presidents on research output in China ([Yu et al., 2024](#)), Italy ([Civera et al., 2025](#)), and Russia ([Gerashchenko, 2022](#)), institutional rankings in the United Kingdom ([Breakwell and Tytherleigh, 2010](#)), and application behavior in the United States ([Bastedo et al., 2014](#)), there is little known about the effect of presidents on a very important collegiate product: education.

In this paper, we investigate the impacts of presidents on school’s faculty and staff. We use employment data from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS) to quantify changes across occupational categories—from instructional staff and student affairs personnel to administrators and support staff—in the years surrounding a leadership change.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 describes the data sources and construction of the analytic sample. Section 3 outlines the empirical framework. Section 4 presents the results, and Section 5 concludes.

2 Data

Our primary data source is the *Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System* ([IPEDS](#)) which collects mandatory annual reports from all US institutions receiving Title IV federal funding. The dataset spans the academic years 2012/13—2023/24 and provides comprehensive institution-level information on employment, institutional characteristics, and student outcomes.

Personnel data comes from two surveys: *Employees by Assigned Position* and *New Hires by Occupational Category*. These surveys report counts of full- and part-time employees across standardized occupational categories and faculty tenure statuses. The *assigned position* variable reflects the employee’s primary paid role, categorized in mutually exclusive groups. We aggregate the 12 detailed IPEDS occupational classifications into three broader employment groups.

1. **Core Services:** Instructional, research, and public service staff; librarians, curators, archivists, and student and academic affairs personnel; and computer, engineering, and science professionals (including graduate assistants).
2. **Administrative:** Management, business and financial operations, sales, and office and administrative support occupations.
3. **Support Staff:** Community and social service, legal, arts, design, entertainment, sports, and media staff; healthcare practitioners and technical staff; service occupations; and natural resources, construction, maintenance, production, and transportation workers.

We identify presidential transitions using changes in the ‘chief executive officer’ name and title from the *Directory Information* survey. We exclude observations in which the CEO title includes the terms ‘interim’ or ‘acting.’ To account for minor variations in name reporting (e.g., middle initials, abbreviations), we employ fuzzy string matching to detect name changes.

We narrow the sample to institutions that are considered ‘Primarily baccalaureate-granting or higher’. Then, we exclude any schools that are for-profit, tribal, become inactive, or have more than 50% of their students ‘exclusively distance’.

Institutions with exactly one presidential transition during the sample period are classified as *treated*, while those with no transitions serve as *controls*. We also include institutions with more than one transition during the sample period as *treated*, focusing only on the

first transition that appears in our data. This procedure yields a balanced sample of 720 institutions, consisting of 475 treated and 245 control units.

Table 1: Balance Table: Treatment vs Control Groups

	(1)				
	Treated	Control	Difference	Std. Error	P-value
total employees	261.45	271.02	9.57	(4.65)	0.04
full-time employees	174.47	177.60	3.13	(3.77)	0.41
part-time employees	90.10	97.64	7.54	(1.62)	0.00
HBCU	1.97	1.94	-0.02	(0.00)	0.00
landgrant	0.05	0.05	-0.00	(0.00)	0.00
public	0.40	0.29	-0.11	(0.00)	0.00
religious affiliation	18.28	23.99	5.71	(0.16)	0.00
open admissions policy	1.86	1.77	-0.09	(0.00)	0.00
institution has hospital	1.95	1.93	-0.02	(0.00)	0.00
institution grants medical degrees	0.11	0.14	0.03	(0.00)	0.00
institution size	2.67	2.61	-0.06	(0.01)	0.00
% of undergrads registered with disabilities	8.58	8.04	-0.55	(0.03)	0.00
total applicants	8,169.76	10,398.29	2,228.53	(76.78)	0.00
total admissions	5,035.82	5,182.98	147.16	(36.12)	0.00
total enrollment	1,202.67	1,310.57	107.90	(8.83)	0.00
SAT math 75th percentile	609.51	614.75	5.24	(0.50)	0.00
SAT math 25th percentile	504.20	510.10	5.89	(0.51)	0.00
ACT composite 75th percentile	26.32	26.63	0.31	(0.02)	0.00
ACT composite 25th percentile	20.91	21.20	0.29	(0.03)	0.00
housing capacity	2,252.76	2,352.12	99.37	(15.04)	0.00
combined food and housing charge	10,917.76	10,435.98	-481.79	(41.85)	0.00
in-state average charges	23,216.79	22,918.34	-298.46	(80.46)	0.00
out-of-state average charges	27,986.62	26,676.38	-1,310.24	(67.31)	0.00
Observations	102,450	52,018			
Institutions	475	245			

3 Research Design

To estimate the causal effect of presidential transitions on institutional employment, we employ an event study design that exploits the timing of leadership changes. Our baseline specification is given by:

$$Y_{it} = \sum_{\substack{k=-5 \\ k \neq -1}}^7 \beta_k D_{i,t-k} + \alpha_i + \lambda_t + X'_{it} \gamma + \varepsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

where Y_{it} represents the outcome of interest for institution i in year t . Our primary outcomes are the number of employees in each of the 12 detailed IPEDS occupational classifications.

The key explanatory variables are a series of indicator variables $D_{i,t-k}$, which equal one if institution i is k years from its presidential transition in year t . We include leads (negative

values of k) to test for pre-existing trends and lags (positive values of k) to capture the dynamic treatment effects following the transition. The reference period is $k = -1$ (one year before the transition), so all coefficients β_k represent differences in outcomes relative to this baseline year.

The coefficients of interest, β_k , capture the difference in employment outcomes for treated institutions k years relative to their presidential transition, compared to never-treated control institutions in the same calendar year. The inclusion of institution fixed effects (α_i) controls for time-invariant institutional characteristics, while year fixed effects (λ_t) account for common temporal shocks affecting all institutions. The vector X_{it} contains time-varying institutional controls that are plausibly exogenous to presidential transitions, including in-state and out-of-state average charges, combined food and housing charges, and the percentage of undergraduates registered with disabilities. Standard errors are clustered at the institution level to account for serial correlation within institutions over time.

The event study framework offers several advantages for our research question. First, the inclusion of pre-treatment periods allows us to test the parallel trends assumption underlying our identification strategy. If the pre-treatment coefficients (β_k for $k < -1$) are statistically indistinguishable from zero, this provides evidence that treated and control institutions followed similar employment trajectories prior to the presidential transition. Second, the multiple post-treatment periods enable us to trace out the dynamic response of employment to leadership changes, revealing whether effects are immediate or emerge gradually over time.

4 Results

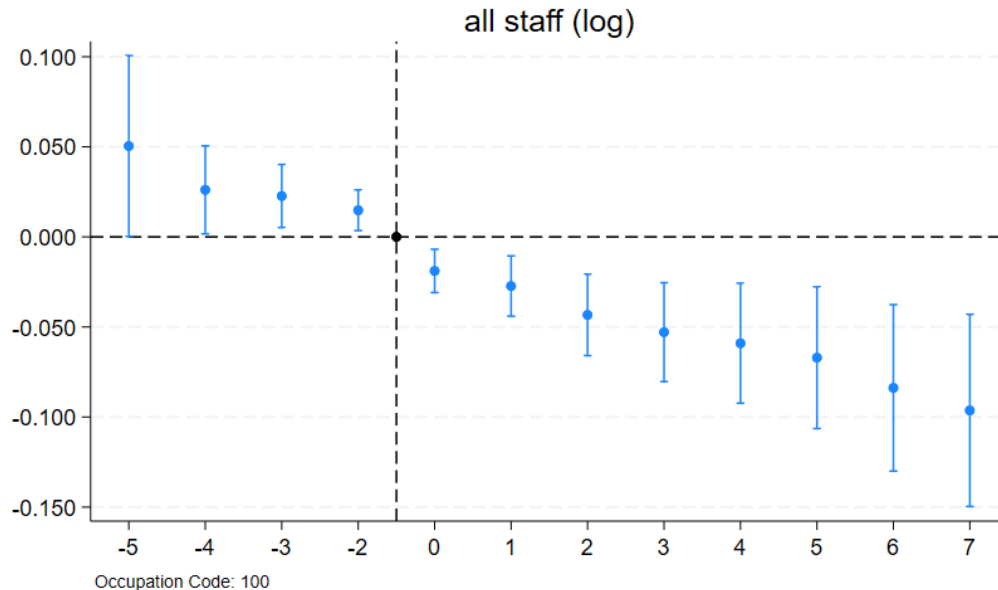
We present our results by examining employment effects across the twelve occupational categories, organized into three functional groups: core services, administrative staff, and support staff. This organization allows us to identify whether presidential transitions generate systematic changes in institutional staffing patterns and to assess which types of positions are most affected by leadership changes.

4.1 Total Employment

We begin by examining the overall effect of presidential transitions on total institutional employment. Figure 1 presents the event study estimates for the total number of employees across all occupational categories. The pre-treatment coefficients are positive but only

marginally significant, indicating that treated and control institutions experienced similar employment trajectories in the years leading up to presidential transitions.

Figure 1: Event Study: Total Employment



Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with total employment as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

Following the transition, we observe a gradual decline in total employment that becomes increasingly pronounced over time. The effect becomes statistically significant in year 1 post-transition and continues to grow through year seven.

The pattern of gradual decline suggests that employment reductions do not occur through immediate, large-scale layoffs but rather through more gradual mechanisms such as hiring freezes, attrition, early retirement incentives, or selective non-replacement of departing employees. The increasing magnitude of the effect over time indicates that these adjustments accumulate across multiple budget cycles following the leadership transition.

Importantly, the aggregate employment decline masks substantial heterogeneity across occupational categories. While total employment decreases, this could reflect large reductions in some categories offset by increases in others, or it could reflect broad-based but modest declines across many categories. In the subsections that follow, we disaggregate total employment into specific occupational categories to identify which types of positions drive

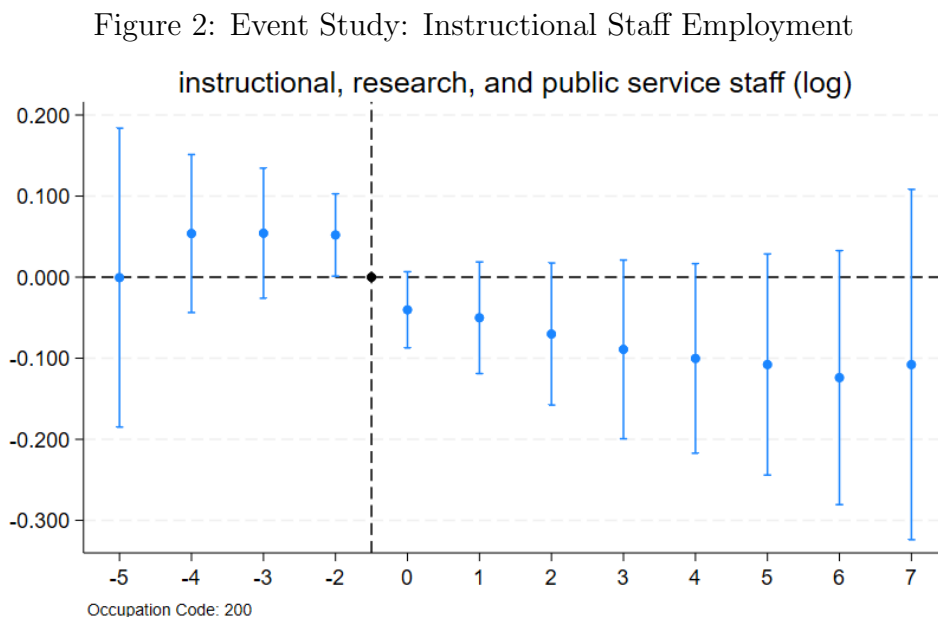
the overall employment reduction and which remain stable or potentially grow under new presidential leadership.

4.2 Core Services Staff

Core services staff represent the academic heart of higher education institutions, encompassing faculty, student support professionals, and specialized technical personnel. We examine four distinct occupational categories within this functional group.

4.2.1 Instructional Staff

Figure 2 presents the event study estimates for instructional staff, which includes faculty members across all ranks and tenure statuses. Again, the pre-treatment coefficients are positive but only marginally significant in one year, indicating that treated and control institutions experienced similar employment trajectories in the years leading up to presidential transitions.



Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Instructional, Research, and Public Service Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

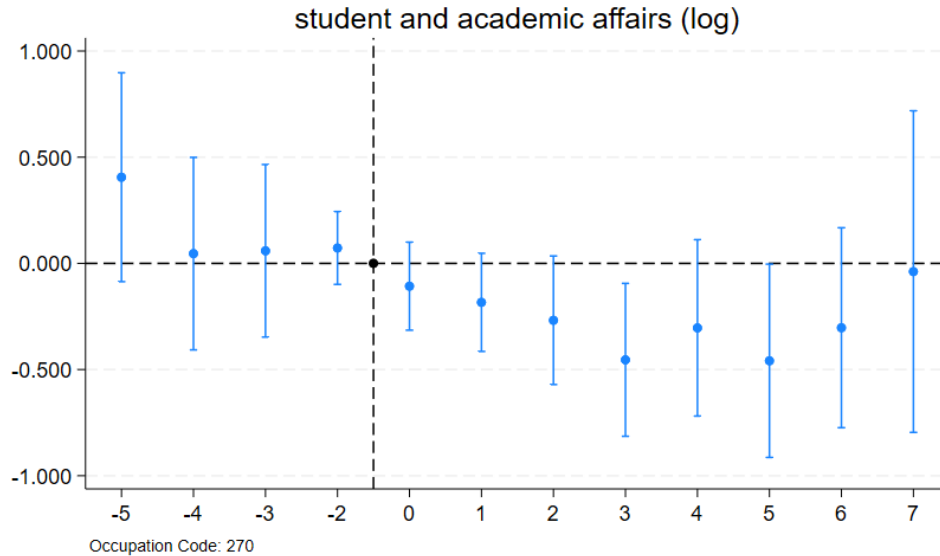
Following the transition, we observe a downward trajectory that emerges immediately post-transition. The effect appears to grow progressively over time, although standard errors also

increase concurrently and no estimate is statistically significant. The gradual nature of this decline suggests that new presidents may implement changes to faculty composition through reduced hiring or non-replacement of departing faculty rather than through immediate layoffs. This pattern is consistent with strategic restructuring that respects existing contractual obligations while adjusting the institution’s trajectory.

4.2.2 Student and Academic Affairs Staff

Student and academic affairs staff (combined with librarians, archivists, and related professionals in IPEDS reporting) also appear to experience reductions following presidential transitions (Figure 3). This category includes professionals who provide direct student services, academic advising, co-curricular programming, and library services. The effect becomes statistically significant in year 3 and point estimates remain negative in the following years.

Figure 3: Event Study: Student and Academic Affairs Staff



Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Student and Academic Affairs Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

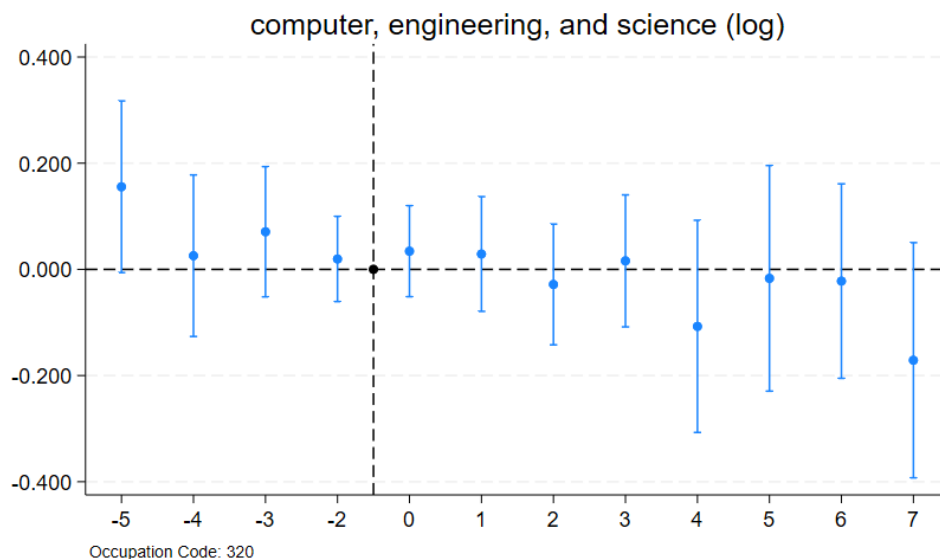
This finding suggests that new presidents may be restructuring student-facing operations, potentially consolidating services, increasing reliance on technology for routine advising functions, or reassessing the optimal staffing levels for student support. The timing of these

reductions, in contrast to instructional staff, suggests deliberate policy choices rather than reactive cost-cutting.

4.2.3 Computer, Engineering, and Science Staff

In contrast to instructional staff and student affairs, we observe no clear effects on computer, engineering, and science staff (Figure 4). The point estimates remain close to zero throughout the pre- and post-treatment periods, with confidence intervals that include zero in all periods. This null result is notable, as IT and technical infrastructure staff represent an increasingly critical function in higher education. The stability of this category may reflect the essential nature of these services, the difficulty of substituting for specialized technical skills, or the challenges of outsourcing core IT functions.

Figure 4: Event Study: Computer, Engineering, and Science Staff



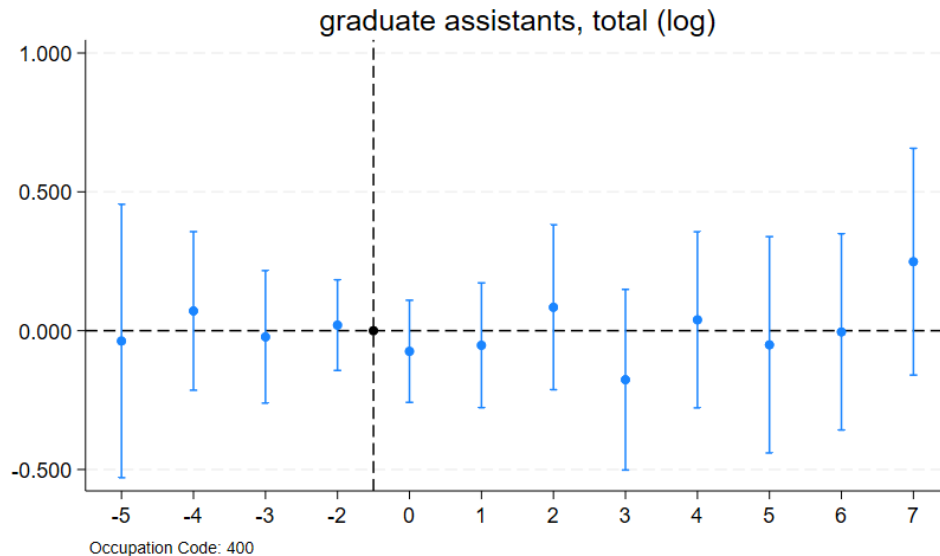
Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Computer, Engineering, and Science Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

4.2.4 Graduate Assistants

Similarly, we observe no significant changes in the employment of graduate assistants (Figure 5). Graduate assistants serve dual roles as both students and employees, providing teaching and research support while pursuing their own degrees. The null result here may

reflect the fact that graduate assistant positions are closely tied to graduate program enrollments and external research funding, which may be less susceptible to presidential influence in the short to medium term.

Figure 5: Event Study: Graduate Assistants



Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Graduate Assistants” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

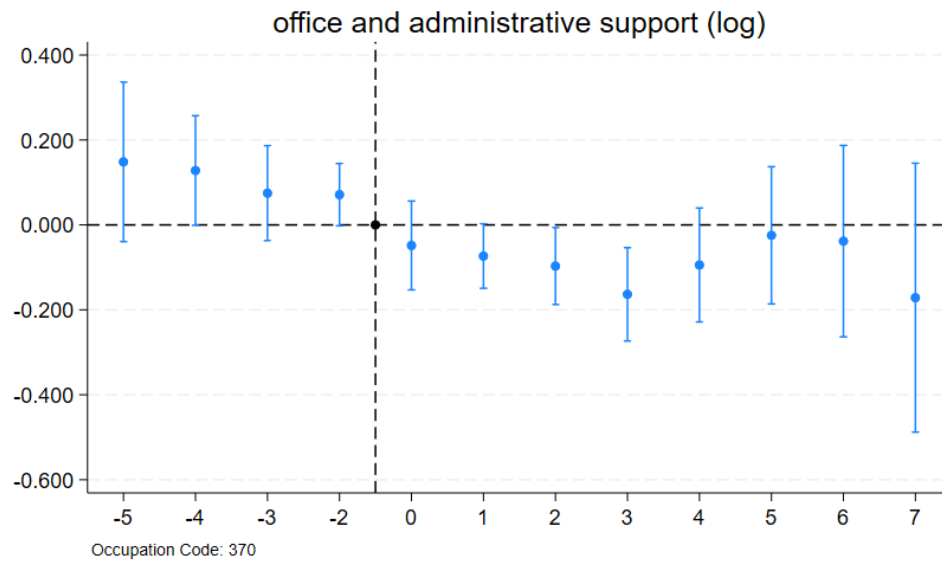
4.3 Administrative Staff

Administrative staff provide essential operational support across institutions. We examine three occupational categories within this functional group, finding mixed evidence of presidential transition effects.

4.3.1 Office and Administrative Support

The most pronounced effect among administrative categories appears in office and administrative support staff (Figure 6). These positions include clerical staff, administrative assistants, secretaries, and other support roles that facilitate day-to-day operations across departments. We observe a decline that becomes statistically significant in year 3, though effects in following years are unclear due to the larger standard errors.

Figure 6: Event Study: Office and Administrative Support Staff



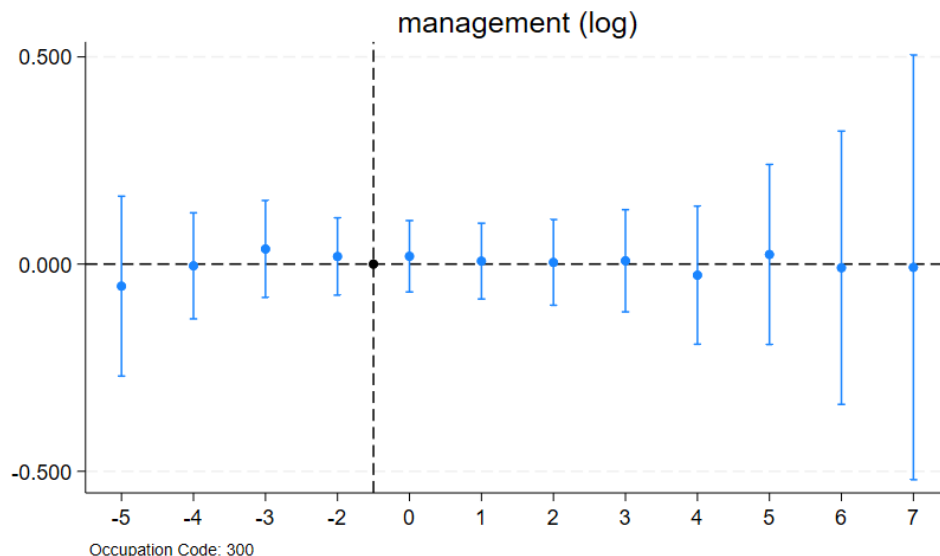
Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Office and Administrative Support Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

This reduction may reflect several mechanisms: new presidents implementing administrative streamlining initiatives, technological substitution for routine clerical tasks (such as automated scheduling, digital document management, and self-service portals), or departmental consolidation that reduces the need for decentralized support staff. The consistency of this effect across institutions suggests that administrative efficiency represents a common priority for new presidential leadership.

4.3.2 Management and Business Operations

Despite the reduction in office support staff, we find no significant changes in management and business operations employment (Figure 7). This category includes senior administrators, human resources professionals, financial officers, and other management personnel. The null result is somewhat surprising, as conventional wisdom might suggest that new presidents bring in their own management teams or restructure senior administrative portfolios.

Figure 7: Event Study: Management Staff



Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Management Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

The stability of this category has several possible interpretations. First, senior administrative positions may be more protected from post-transition adjustments due to contractual protections or the cost of executive turnover. Second, changes in management may occur

primarily through natural attrition rather than systematic reductions, making them difficult to detect in aggregate employment levels. Third, while individual managers may turn over, the total number of management positions may remain stable as new presidents maintain existing organizational structures.

4.3.3 Sales and Related Occupations

We find no evidence of changes in sales and related occupations (Figure 8). This category represents a relatively small fraction of total institutional employment and includes positions related to admissions recruiting, bookstore operations, and other revenue-generating activities. The null result suggests that these functions remain stable across presidential transitions.

Figure 8: Event Study: Sales and Related Occupations Staff



Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Sales and Related Occupations Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

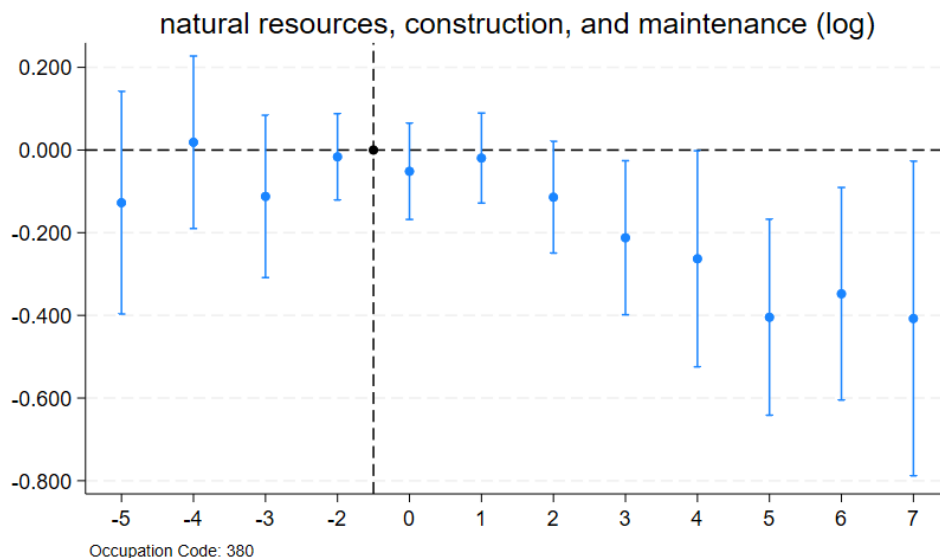
4.4 Support Staff

Support staff provide a wide range of services essential to campus operations, from facilities maintenance to healthcare services. We examine five occupational categories within this functional group.

4.4.1 Natural Resources, Construction, and Maintenance

Facilities and maintenance staff experience significant reductions following presidential transitions (Figure 9). This category includes groundskeepers, custodial staff, maintenance workers, and other personnel responsible for the physical plant. The effect emerges in year 3 and grows until year 5, representing one of the largest proportional reductions we observe across all occupational categories.

Figure 9: Event Study: Natural Resources, Construction, and Maintenance Staff



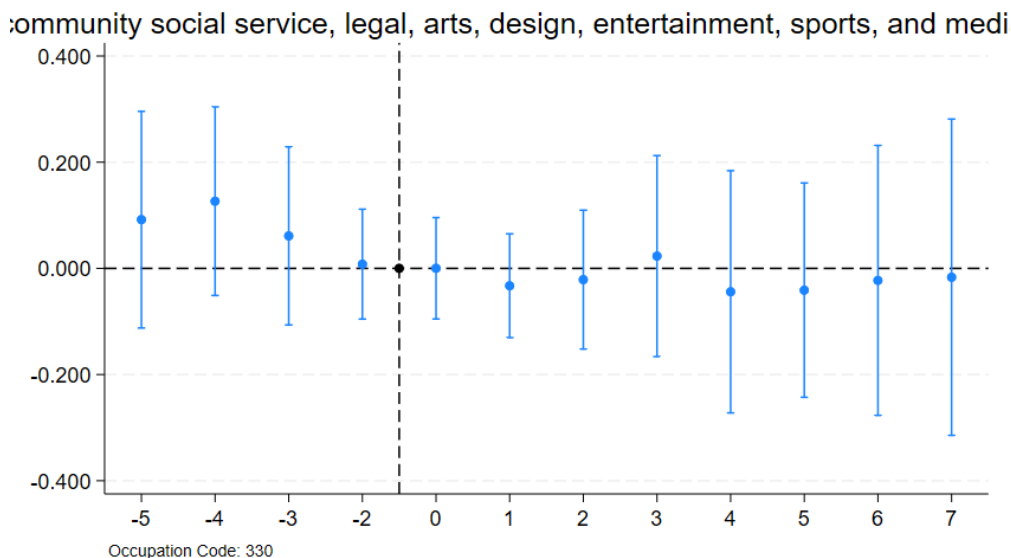
Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Natural Resources, Construction, and Maintenance Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

This finding may reflect several strategic decisions by new presidents. First, institutions may increasingly outsource facilities management to private contractors, converting in-house employees to contracted services that do not appear in IPEDS employment counts. Second, new presidents may defer maintenance or reduce the frequency of routine upkeep in response to budget pressures, reducing staffing needs. Third, institutions may consolidate facilities operations or adopt more efficient maintenance scheduling that requires fewer workers. The magnitude and persistence of this effect suggests that facilities management represents a common target for operational restructuring under new leadership.

4.4.2 Community, Social Service, Legal, Arts, and Media Staff

We find no statistically significant effects on this diverse occupational category (Figure 10), which includes counselors, social workers, legal professionals, public relations staff, and arts professionals. The point estimates remain close to zero throughout the observation period. This stability may reflect the specialized nature of these positions and their importance to institutional reputation and student well-being.

Figure 10: Event Study: Community, Social Service, Legal, Arts, and Media Staff

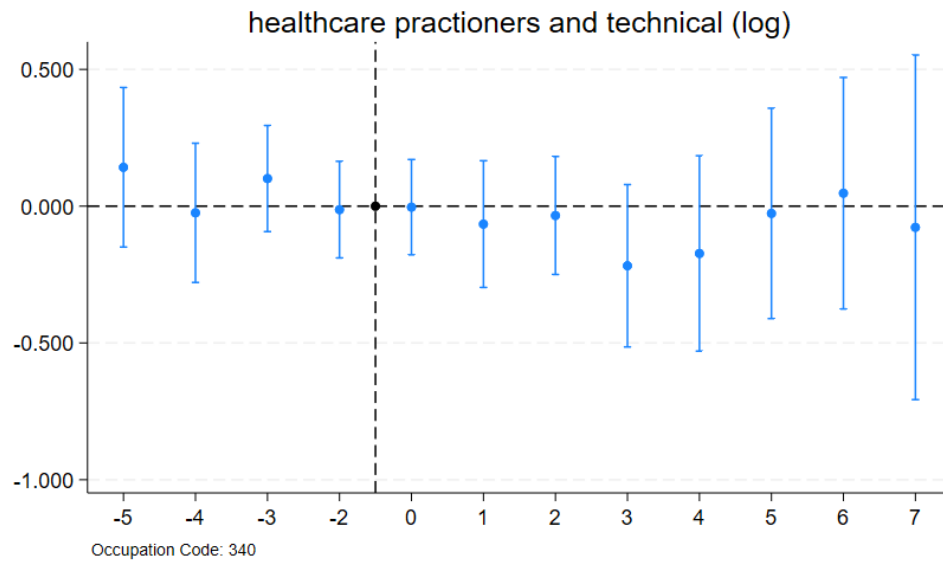


Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Community, Social Service, Legal, Arts, and Media Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

4.4.3 Healthcare Practitioners and Technical Staff

Healthcare staff employment shows no significant response to presidential transitions (Figure 11). This null result is particularly notable at institutions with medical facilities, student health centers, or teaching hospitals. It suggests that clinical operations remain insulated from presidential transition effects, possibly due to regulatory requirements, patient care obligations, external revenue sources (such as clinical billings), or the challenges of adjusting highly credentialed healthcare workforces.

Figure 11: Event Study: Healthcare Practioners and Technical Staff

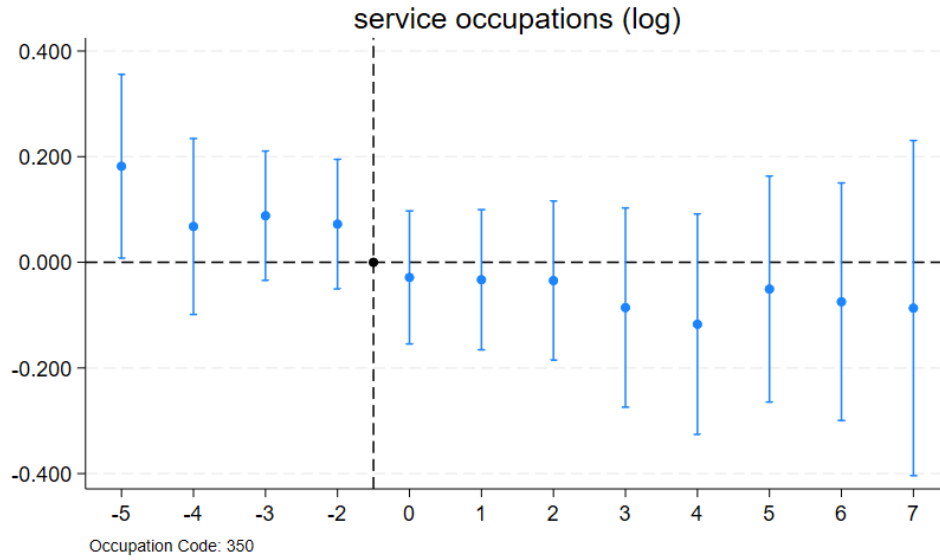


Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Healthcare Practioners and Technical Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

4.4.4 Service Occupations

Service occupations, which include food service workers, protective services, and other service personnel, show no significant changes following presidential transitions (Figure 12). Many of these functions, particularly food service and custodial work in residence halls, may already be outsourced at many institutions, limiting the scope for presidents to affect employment levels. Additionally, service levels in these areas may be closely tied to enrollment levels, which do not change dramatically in the short term.

Figure 12: Event Study: Service Occupations Staff

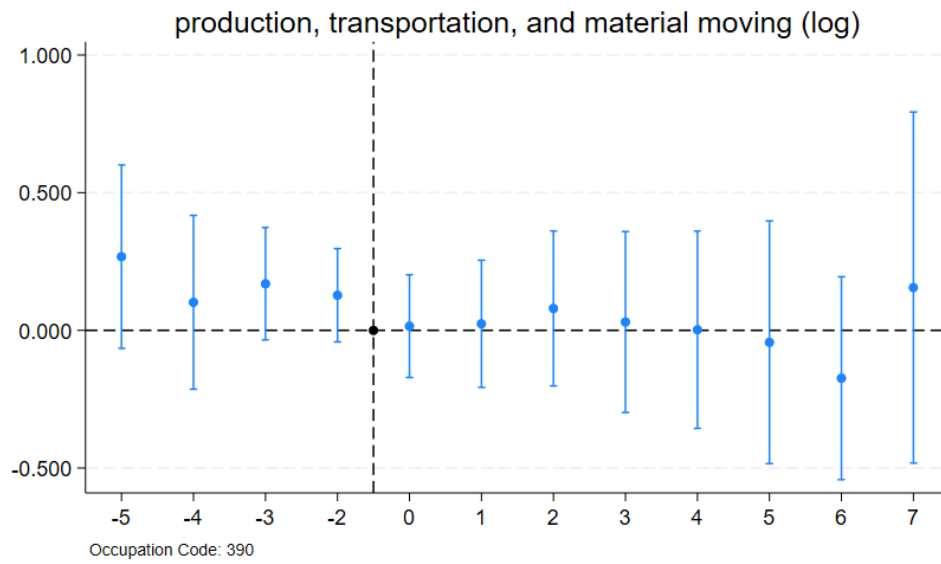


Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Service Occupations Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

4.4.5 Production, Transportation, and Material Moving

Finally, we observe no significant effects on production, transportation, and material moving workers (Figure 13). This small occupational category includes positions such as equipment operators, delivery personnel, and warehouse workers. The null result likely reflects the small size and specialized nature of these roles.

Figure 13: Event Study: Production, Transportation, and Material Moving Staff



Notes: This figure plots event study coefficients from equation (1) with the number of employees in the occupational category “Production, Transportation, and Material Moving Staff” as the outcome variable. The vertical axis measures the change in number of employees relative to one year before the presidential transition. The horizontal axis indicates years relative to the transition, with year -1 serving as the reference period. Dots represent point estimates and vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered at the institution level. The dashed vertical line marks the year of the presidential transition.

5 Discussion

Across the twelve occupational categories, we find evidence of significant employment reductions in four areas: instructional staff, student and academic affairs, office and administrative support, and facilities maintenance. Notably, we find no evidence of employment growth in any occupational category during the seven-year post-transition window. This asymmetry is striking—new presidents are associated with staffing reductions in specific areas but not with expansion of institutional capacity elsewhere.

The timing of effects is generally consistent across the four affected categories. Declines typically emerge 2-3 years after the presidential transition and grow progressively over time rather than appearing immediately. This pattern suggests strategic restructuring implemented through attrition and reduced hiring rather than sudden workforce reductions. The lag may also reflect the time required for new presidents to complete institutional assessments, develop strategic plans, secure governing board approval, and implement changes through annual budget cycles.

The heterogeneity across occupational categories is equally revealing. The eight categories showing no significant effects—including librarians, computer staff, graduate assistants, management, sales, community services, healthcare, and various service occupations—collectively represent a substantial fraction of institutional employment. This pattern suggests that presidential transitions do not uniformly affect all institutional functions. Instead, new presidents appear to target specific areas that may offer greater flexibility for adjustment, lower political costs, or higher potential for efficiency gains.

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